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Public Speaking

Lecture 09: Role of Personality in Public Speaking

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Personality may be defined as the most characteristic integration of an individual's structures, modes of interests, attitude, behaviour, capacities, abilities and aptitudes.

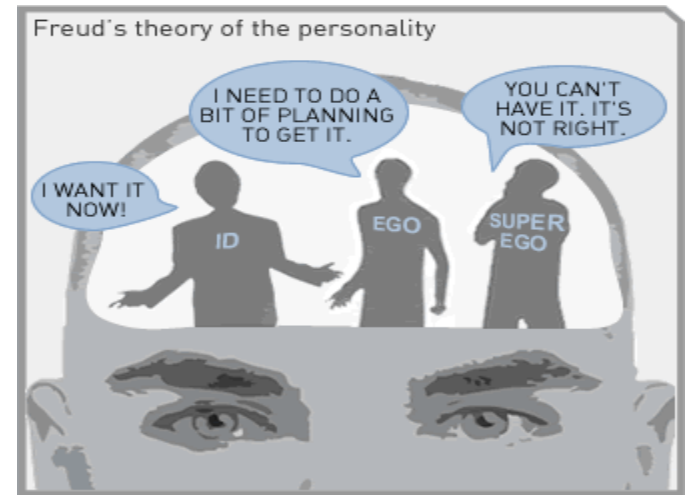
(NL Munn)

What is Personality?

- ❑ 'Personality': Etymology – Derived from the Latin word *persona*, which means mask.
- ❑ It comprises a comprehensive set of attributes:
 - Physique
 - Dress
 - Communication Skills
 - Attitude
 - Values
 - Emotions

Psychic Attributes of Personality

- According to Sigmund Freud's psychoanalytic theory, the human personality is governed by three distinct interacting agents of the psychic apparatus: Id, Ego and the Superego.



Id

- The primitive and instinctual part of the mind.
- Contains aggressive drives, desires and memories.
- Operates through Pleasure Principle.

Ego

- Mediates between the desires of Id and the Superego.
- Operates through Reality Principle.

Superego

- Inhibits the impulses of Id and persuades the Ego to strive for moralistic ideals.
- Operates as a moral conscience.

Personality and Public Speaking

- Speech is perceived as a form of self-expression.



- When a speaker communicates his ideas, he unintentionally reveals his personality, emotions and attitude.
- ***“Speech and personality grow, develop, differentiate and become refined together. Speech is a phase of personality.” - Elwood Murray***

Personality and Speech Proficiency: A Correlational Study

- Empirical evidences suggest that personality variables influence the speech proficiency of an individual.
- An instance can be cited -
 - **Premise:** Oration requires both short-term as well as long-term memory.
 - **Hypothesis:** Extroverts possess short-term memory whereas introverts are do well at long-term recall.
 - **Conclusion:** Extroverts excel at speech production which stems from their superior verbal processing capacity induced from their ability to short-term recall.
- Certain distinguishing traits, for instance; self-confidence, extraversion, intelligence, verbal fluency and composure go into the personality make-up of a competent speaker.
- Speech, therefore, reflects the personality of the speaker.



PERSONALITY TRAITS OF THE SPEAKER



INTRINSIC WORTH OF THE SPEAKER
(established by the personality traits)



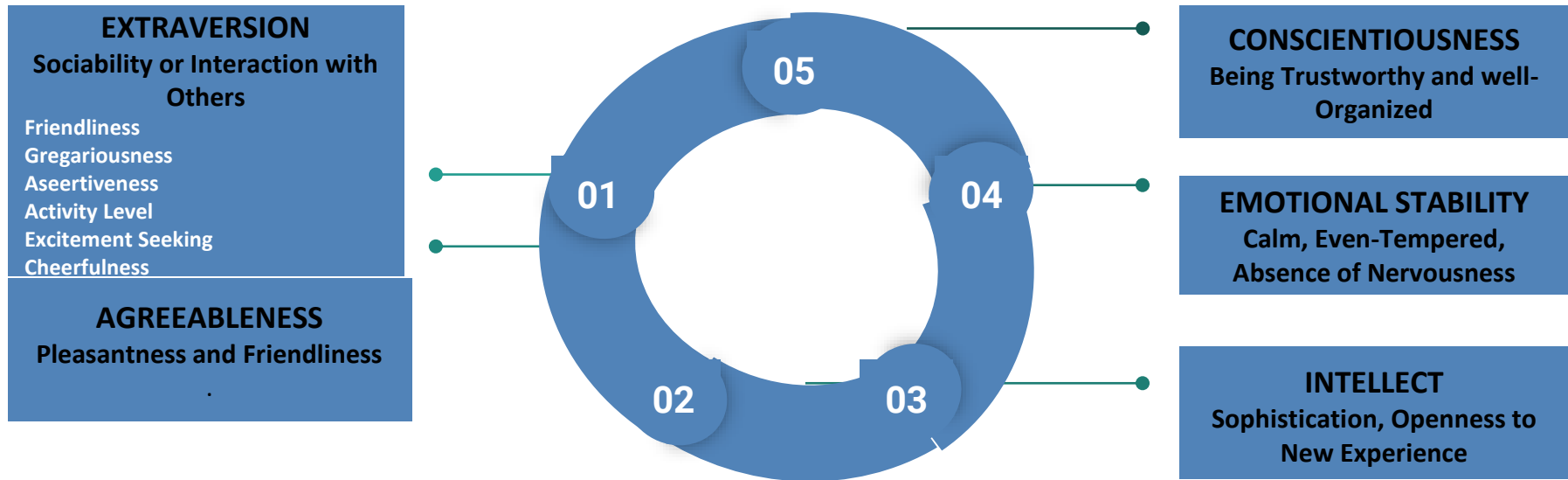
POSITIVE RESPONSE FROM THE AUDIENCE
(stimulated by the intrinsic worth)



EFFICIENT PUBLIC SPEAKER

The Five-Factor Model

McCrae and Costa have forwarded an all-inclusive **Five-Factor Model** (FFM) for the categorisation of the global personality traits.



Does Personality impact Public Speaking?

- ❑ The personality of the speaker in toto - intrinsic traits, appearance, voice, movements, diction - go into the modelling of a proficient speaker.
- ❑ **Sarett and Foster**, in their book *Basic Principles of Speech*, outline the vital impact of the following personality traits on the skill of oration:
 - ❑ **Extraversion**: A public speaker is required to be extrovert, sociable and objective in order to cast an influence on the audience.
 - ❑ **Agreeableness**: A pleasant and friendly attitude of the speaker helps to win over the audience.



- ❑ **Conscientiousness:** Being trustworthy and well-organized procures credibility to the speaker.
- ❑ **Emotional Stability:** An impactful speaker ought to manifest emotional maturity and keep up a composed bearing while delivering a speech.
- ❑ **Intellect:** As the thumb rule goes, intellectuals possessing the faculty of critical thinking and knowledgeable ideas emerge as better speakers.
- ❑ **Self-Confidence:** Like in all other avenues, in Public Speaking too, self-confidence is the key to success.

- ❑ **Fluency:** Verbal fluency and adept communicative skill is fundamental to convey speaker's ideas and emotions without any confusion.
- ❑ **Vocals:** The appropriate use of voice, volume, tone, and pauses helps to communicate nuances of speaker's emotion and thoughts, adding weight to the ideas presented.
- ❑ **Presentability:** Attractive personality of the speaker - groomed up appearance, well-donned clothes, kempt hair and a confident smile - aids in captivating the attention of the audience towards a greater acceptability of the speaker and his/her message.
- ❑ **Integrity:** Personal integrity of the speaker and a positive attitude towards life and society plays an important role in audience stimulation and thereby adds to the acclaim of the speaker.

PUBLIC SPEAKER: SPEECH ATTITUDE				PUBLIC SPEAKER: PERSONALITY
1	I am ill at ease when speaking with a group	✗	✓	Are you talkative at social gatherings?
2	I enjoy meeting and talking with famous people.	✓	✗	Do you feel self-conscious in the presence of superiors?
3	I enjoy making a speech in a large auditorium.	✓	✗	Do you find it difficult to speak in public?
4	I find it easy to solicit money for a cause which interests me.	✓	✗	Are you troubled with shyness?
5	I hesitate to protest even though I feel I have been wronged.	✗	✓	Do you try to get your own way even if you have to fight for it?

Categories of Public Speakers and their Personality Traits

CATEGORY OF PUBLIC SPEAKER	PERSONALITY TRAITS
AVOIDER	Does everything possible to escape from facing an audience. Is generally an introvert.
RESISTOR	Has fear of speaking in public. Is a reluctant individual.
ACCEPTOR	Gives presentations occasionally as part of the job. Doesn't seek those opportunities.
SEEKER	Looks for opportunities to speak in public Is usually a confident extrovert who can effectively overcome anxiety and the fear of speaking in public.

Do's and Don'ts of Personal Appearance

Do

- ❖ Stay close, stay direct, stay involved with your audience.
- ❖ Use your facial expressions.
- ❖ Vary your pitch, volume and tone in your voice.

Don't

- ❖ Keep hands in your pocket
- ❖ Keep your arms crossed
- ❖ Wring your hands nervously
- ❖ Have too soft voice - Lack of confidence
- ❖ Make too loud voice - Excessively dominant

Do

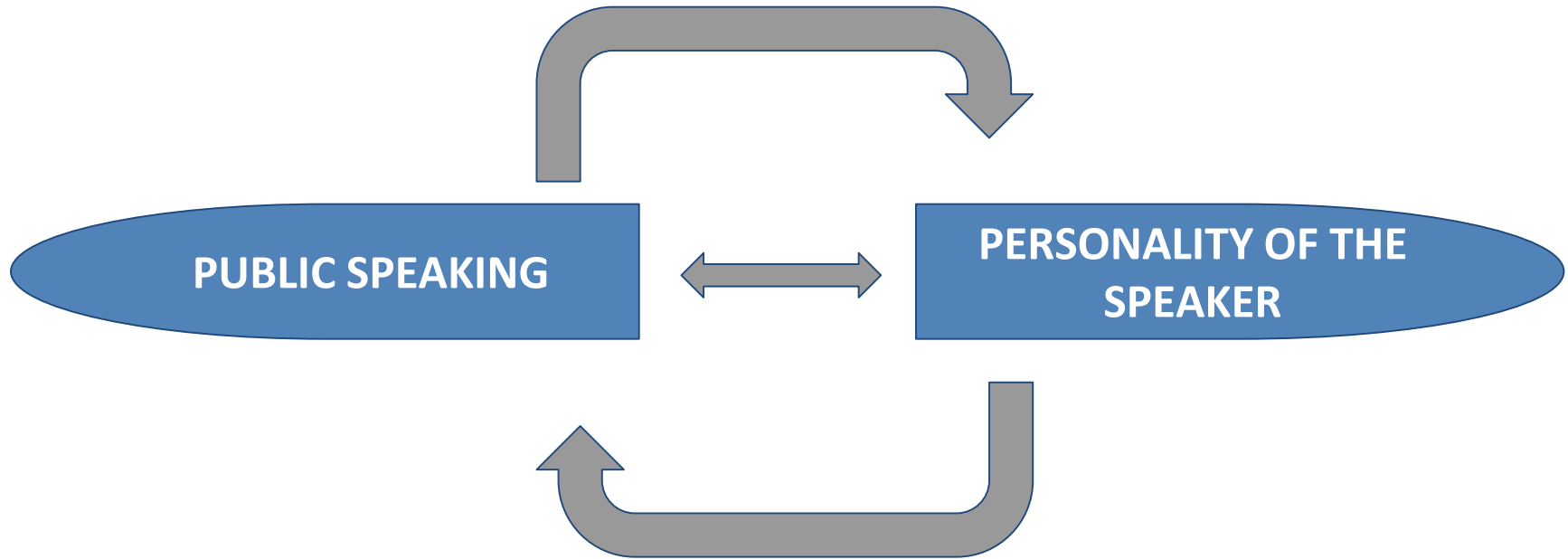
- ❖ Keep your posture erect.
- ❖ Maintain good eye contact with different parts of the audience.
- ❖ Watch your conversational pace.
- ❖ Allow pauses during the presentation.
- ❖ Encourage your audience to ask questions.

Don't

- ❖ Posture should not be stiff or unnatural.
- ❖ Eye contact should not be too long to make the person feel uncomfortable (3 to 5 seconds per person).
- ❖ Avoid too tight or too loose clothing, sparkling jewelry, heavy make-up, tinted lenses.



Public Speaking and Personality: An Inter-Relational Continuum



- Personality of the speaker and the skill of Public Speaking are complementary to each other - proficiency at speech possesses a strong correlation with the speaker's personality traits.
- These two flourish simultaneously and mutually, interacting aspects of the individual's holistic development.
- Speech, as per scholar Eisenson, is a reflection of speaker's experiences in entirety - innate as well as environmental.
- The efficiency of Public Speaking is directly proportional to the development of personality of the speaker. Hence, they are integral to and constitutive of each other.



Personality Traits developed by Public Speaking

- ✓ Better Thinkers
- ✓ Confident Individuals
- ✓ Proficient Communicators
- ✓ Reliable Beings
- ✓ Assertive Leaders
- ✓ High Emotional Quotient

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*“What you are speaks so loud, I cannot hear
what you say.”*

W. T. Foster

Thank You

